Haiku

By Katherine Snodgrass

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested character assignments:
ACTRESS 1: Nell (50's mother to Billie and Louise) / ACTRESS 2: Billie (Bebe) and Louise (Lulu) – Both in their late 20s to early 30s

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *A haiku is a short poem that expresses a single feeling or impression and typically contains three unrhymed lines of five, seven, and five syllables.*
ACTRESS 2 (as Lulu): *(in a sing-song voice, rocking and flapping) May not have the words / to share my experience / Understand me still*
ACTRESS 1: *See . . . that was a haiku . . . In this selection, haikus becomes a bridge between a severely mentally handicapped daughter and her mother -- A way for Lulu to make a connection with reality and release the artist trapped inside her damaged mind.*
ACTRESS 2 (as Lulu): *(in a sing-song voice, rocking and flapping) May not have the words / to share my experience / Understand me still*
ACTRESS 1: *If only they can convince Lulu's sister, Bebe, that it's true*
TOGETHER: *Haiku by Katherine Snodgrass*

Scene opens with Louise rocking and flapping her hands. She is lost in her own mentally disabled word. Nell begins speaking . . . almost to herself rather than to Louise.

NELL: You were born in early winter. A breech baby. You tried to back into the world. I remember, the doctor had to pull you out. It was night when they finally brought you to me.

LOUISE: *(still rocking and flapping – in a sing-song voice)* November evening. / Blackbirds scull across the moon. / My breath warms my hands. *(Nell write down Louise's haiku, then check what she has written holding the paper two inches from her eyes)*

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NELL: John said you were too beautiful to live. It was true. You and Bebe together, you were like china dolls. Delicate, perfect. And then . . . I sensed it that day when I saw you through the window. Billie was on the swingset, and you were there. Outside. You were so quiet. You'd stared before, of course . . . as all children do. But this time, you were . . . different. I had to get down on my knees beside you. I touched your hair and then your face. . . Funny, I don't remember being afraid.

LOUISE: *(less rocking and flapping –sing-song voice is dying out to be replaced with a normal tone)* Chainmetal swings clanging / In the empty schoolyard. / Silent summer rain. *(Nell writes down this haiku and goes through the same process as before) (in a normal voice – Louise is fully present)* Tell me again about John. You haven't talked about John in a long time.

NELL: John. All right then. John was tall and thin like Icabod Crane, only not so scared.

LOUISE: John wasn't scared of anything. And [he] would rub Bebe's back until she went to sleep. He smelled of soap and something . . . sweet?

NELL: *(Drily)* Sweet! Cigars. From Havana.

LOUISE: *(retreating into her own world again as she repeats with Nell's exact inflection – beginning to rock)* Cigars. From Havana.

NELL: *(Looks at her sharply)* Let's stop now. I think I should give you your medicine.

LOUISE: *(struggles to stop rocking and maintain her connection - normal voice again)* I'm not ready to go back. Please, not yet. I want to do more.

NELL: We've got to be careful.

LOUISE: *(haltingly – she is clearly battling to maintain her clarity)* But I can do it! I promise. Please, Momma, It's like being smothered. Everything is so dim, and I can't hear you properly. Or see you or touch you or . . . *(Louise sees a bruise on Nell's arm)* Did I do that?

NELL: It's not bad. *(Nell touches the bandage on Louise's forehead)* Does this still hurt?

LOUISE: That was before, before I knew what to do. I can stop it, I know I can. I need

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to practice, you said so yourself. *(beginning to rock and flap as she become more distressed)*

NELL: Yes, I know what I said, but . . .

LOUISE: Let me see Bebe first.

NELL: Billie! My God, what time is it?

LOUISE: *(Repeating)* My God, what time is it? *(Nell fishes in her pocket for a bottle of pills, urgently)*

NELL: She'll be here any minute. Sit quietly. You know we can't wait too long. You'll hurt yourself.

LOUISE: *(sing-song voice)* You'll hurt yourself. *(again pulls herself back)* I mean no, I won't and you promised I could talk to Bebe. You said I had to talk to her this time. That we could show her.

NELL: We will, we will. But she'll be here any moment. *(Holding out pills)* I want you to take this now. *(Louise retreats into her world and begins to rock and flap in ernest) (Billie enters in a whirlwind)*

BILLIE: Whew, I made it. *(To Nell, ignoring Louise)* How are you? You look exhausted. I knew you'd be surprised. Oh, and look what I found in a little shop in Boston. They had all three of your books, is that unbelievable? I brought something for Lulu, too. *(Billing brings out a package from her bag and hands it to Nell.)*

NELL: You did? Why, that was thoughtful. It's wrapped so prettily, why don't you let Lulu open it?

BILLIE: *(Laughing nervously)* Do we have time before dinner?

NELL: Billie.

BILLIE: I'm sorry. It's just that she'll like the wrapping paper better than the music box. *(Crosses to Lulu)* My God, what happened to her forehead? Is she banging her had again?

NELL: No, no, of course not. We just had a little accident.

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BILLIE: Isn't the medicine working? *(Noticing Nell's bruise)* Did you get that bruise at the same time?

NELL: *(Lying)* Oh, this? This is nothing. I don't even remember where it got it.

LOUISE: *(Holding up her hands for a hug)* Bebe.

BILLIE: God lord. Lulu, my love, you amaze me. *(Louise and Billie hug)*

NELL: She's different than when you saw her last, isn't she?

BILLIE: Because she hugged me? At least the medicine is doing that for her.

NELL: But don't you think she's really getting better thought? Honestly, look at her. Isn't she more alert? She knew you, Billie. She wanted to touch you.

BILLIE: *(Laughing)* Mother. No! *(to Louise)* You never change, do you? *(To Nell)* No, I don't see any difference, no, she's not more alert, and no, she's not getting any better.

NELL: You don't understand. You can't possibly know, you don't see her every day. *(long beat)* I'm glad you're here, Billie. I'm glad you came. I've been wanting to talk to you, but I haven't had the courage until now. *(silence, then frustrated)* It's my eyes.

BILLIE: Yes. That's why I'm here. Doctor Dave called me. Don't look so horrified. What did you expect him to do? Ignore it? *(beat)* What are we going to do? Will Daddy's trust fund cover a nurse for Lulu?

NELL: No, and even if it would, I don't want some stranger in my house caring for Lulu. I'll do it myself.

BILLIE: How? How will you measure her medicine? What if she dirties her clothes? What if she has a reaction to the medicine? What if you were to fall, what would happen to Lulu? She couldn't help you. She wouldn't know what to do. Why, she wouldn't even understand that anything was wrong.

NELL: I do not have to have someone here. I've managed this long. Besides . . . Lulu understands more than you know. Billie . . . I don't write the haikus . . . Louise does . . .

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BILLIE: That's impossible

NELL: I swear it. It started two years ago. Right after we changed to that new medication. I was reading and Lulu was sitting next to the window and suddenly I realized that I'd forgotten to give her her pill. She turned to me and looked at me . . . really looked at me for the first time.

LOUISE: Mama? Do you forgive me Mama? Don't mean to hurt you, but I get so scared as if . . . I get trapped, Mama. I try and I try, but I'm moving so slowly. I can't tell you . . . *(she gets stuck and there's a growing panic to her voice and her demeanor – gradually increase of rocking and flailing)* I can't . . . I can't . . . I can't!

NELL: I had to give her her medicine then, but Louise had been there! She was so frightened. And then I remembered . . . The medicine . . . on that day it was late. So on the third day, again, I held back the pill, and again she was Louise!

BILLIE: This happened two years ago? Why didn't you tell me? And the poetry?

NELL: It was October, just about dusk . . . I said to her "Concentrate, Lulu, you can stay if you want to. Look how beautiful the colors are . . *(sing-song)* Autumn evening:

LOUISE: *(with same sing-song inflection - rocking)* Autumn evening . . .

NELL: *(sing-song)* Woodsmoke

LOUISE: *(imitate)* Woodsmoke . .

NELL: *(sing-song)* Curling up wood . . .

LOUISE: *(imitate)* Curling up wood . . . *(then finish without sing-song as the rocking and flapping ceases)* swallows circle . . . . overhead.

NELL: She had finished it for me, you see. A Haiku. After that Lulu began making them up all on her own. Now I simply sit and talk and she creates. Billie, it's as if she sees my thoughts, my innermost feelings, and then she translates them into images.

BILLIE: I thought they were yours.

NELL: I know you did. But no, I'm only the catalyst.

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BILLIE: Catalyst. Is this every day? *(Nell shakes her head)* How long does it last?

NELL: Half an hour at the most. But she's trying very hard. She wants to practice. She wants to be . . .

BILLIE: . . . Normal?

NELL: No. More than that. She wants to be extraordinary. And she is.

BILLIE: Mother, if this is true . . .

NELL: If . . . ?

BILLIE: I mean, when this happens . . . Why haven't you told Dr. Dave about it?

NELL: No doctors and no more hospitals. They brought on this problem in the first place. If I hadn't rushed her to the doctors so quickly, maybe she would have come out of it. If they didn't have her taking all these drugs . . . Nobody knows what might have happened!

BILLIE: If that's what you believe, take her off the drugs. We could put her in the hospital and have the drug levels monitored.

NELL: No. I told you, no hospitals.

BILLIE: But they could wean her off the drugs slowly, and then we could . . *(Nell is shaking her head)* Why not? Why not?

NELL: She needs the drugs. She's not herself yet, so she needs them to . . . to protect her until . . .

BILLIE: What do you mean, protect her from what?

NELL: I told her you wouldn't understand. I warned her, but she wanted me to tell you. She said we had to tell you.

BILLIE: I don't believe it . . . .

(Flashback to BILLIE AND LULU as teens – Billie is teaching Louise about makeup.)

BILLIE: *(To imaginary mirror)* Now then, we need this, and this, and this. Okay, now you take the lipstick and you put in on like . . . that. See? Okay. Pucker up. *(Billie puckers and Louise imitates her as Billie applies lipstick to Louise's mouth then to her*

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own) M-m-m-, luscious pink! Now then, you take this pencil. And don't put it in your eye!

LOUISE: *(Sing-song with lots of rocking and flapping)* Don't put it in your eye!

BILLIE: *(To mirror, applying makeup to herself)* You draw around the eye . . . underneath . . . above . . . but not too much. There. See?

LOUISE: *(Sing-song with lots of rocking and flapping)* Don't put it in your eye!

BILLIE: Right. And now for the shadow. What color shall we use? Let's use turquoise, or what about this purple? Yeah, let's use the purple.

LOUISE: Yeah, let's use the purple! *(Billie puts it on for the mirror while Louise picks up turquoise and draws circles over her face, her cheeks and above her eyes).*

BILLIE: Now, then, what's next?

LOUISE: Now, then, what's next? *(Billie looks at Louise, whose face is covered with makeup)* Oh, you!

NELL: *(Enters)* Billie, how could you! I thought you knew better than this. What were you thinking? Oh, Lulu, such a mess. It'll take days for these colors to wear off. Why on earth? Here, hold her hands while I clean off this mess. For the final time, do not take it upon yourself to teach her. You leave that to me, or you can leave this house. Do you understand? *(Billie runs off stage)* I have no time to clean up after the both of you. Look at this, just look at it! Lulu, be still! Billie!

(End Flashback)

BILLIE: What do you want me to do?

NELL: I want for you, I need for you to write down the poems. To listen to her and believe in her so that she can be . . . who she is. The doctors don't understand. The illness is still in control, so it's only sheer will power that allows her to get out at all. If you don't believe me, let me show you . . . . You can talk to her. We can help her, I know it. Louise? *(There is no sign from Louise)* Louise. *(Louise still does not respond)*

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BILLIE: She doesn't hear you.

NELL: Billie's here, and you wanted to talk to her. Remember? *(Nell turns Louise's head toward Billie)* You see? There. Now, Bebe, say something to her. Go on.

BILLIE: *(Hesitantly)* Lulu. It's Billie.

LOUISE: Bebe.

BILLIE: Yes. Is it really you?

LOUISE: Is it really you?

BILLIE: I mean, is it true?

LOUISE: True?

BILLIE: *(Trying again after looking at Nell for encouragement)* It's been a long time since I've seen you, Lulu. How . . . How are you?

LOUISE: How are you?

BILLIE: I've been fine, but how are you?

LOUISE: I've been fine.

BILLIE: *(Giving up)* She's just repeating, Mother . . . No, no, say something else. Say anything else. Make up a poem. Can you do that for me, Lulu? Make up a poem. Please do that. *(To Nell)* What if I point out the window, will that help? *(To Louise)* Look, look out there. Winter's nearly over. Mr. Turner's daffodils are in bloom see?

NELL: Keep going, she's listening.

BILLIE: One gray cloud lies just . . . over the trees across the southwest.

LOUISE: Over the trees one gray cloud lies . . .

BILLIE: She's mimicking me.

LOUISE: . . . in my sister's eyes.

NELL: There! Bravo, Lulu! Good girl! *(Nell turns to Billie and sees her face)* What.

BILLIE: She's repeating. She says nursery rhymes with the same rhythm. She's repeating what I say and what you say.

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NELL: No. Louise? Help me now. We've got to make Bebe understand. Louise? Try just a little harder, baby. Concentrate now.

BILLIE: Please, please don't! I'm asking you to stop.

NELL: Louise, answer me. Look at me and answer.

BILLIE: *(Shouting)* Mother stop! *(Louise is startled by the shout and begins screaming and banging her head against her chair)* Where is her medicine?

NELL: On the desk. Get the water. *(Billie instead crosses to where she has put the music box and opens it for Louise to see. Louise immediately stops the banging and screaming and focuses on the music. Billie brings the pill and water glass to Nell)* Now take this, Lulu. There. *(Louise takes the pill calmly, fascinated with the music box).*

BILLIE: Is this what always happens?

NELL: No, but sometimes we wait too long . . . I hate so to see her leave. *(Beat)* I know what you're going to say. But every word I've told you is true. You heard it, but you didn't want to believe.

BILLIE: That's not true. I want to believe. Just don't ask me to see something that isn't' there. Momma, I'm sorry, but I've tried before. I can't keep trying and have it not be . . . not be true. It hurts too much. You talk to her as if . . .

NELL: . . . as if she's real, as if she's a person. And she is. Let me try tomorrow . . . I'm only asking you to let me try. Wait and see. You'll do that, won't you? Just that? For me?

BILLIE: *(resigned and defeated)* Yes, Momma. I think I can do that. *(Billie crosses to the window and stands, looking out)* I wish Daddy could be here. *(Exits scene)*

LOUISE: *(alone on stage)* Walking in his garden / Suddenly in the twilight / White hydrangea

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Katherine Snodgrass
ISBN: 978-0573632549
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): 1989

AWARD HISTORY

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